

you have a tool that can be used on a night safari (or Osama assassination raid) without losing track of direction! In this example, we want to highlight the fact that augmented reality is not dependent on an internet connection. Such a device would work via an inbuilt electronic compass. You'll find out more about exactly how, in the later chapters.

Mediated reality

Just like augmented reality is about enhancing the perception of the world around us by adding more information to it, a mediated reality is about mediating it. Mediation means “coming in between two things to affect an agreement”. Here the two things are you and “the reality”, well, the ‘real’ reality for that matter (hence we write it as the reality)!

If you're wondering “Isn't augmented reality the same a mediated reality? After all augmentation too comes in between us and the reality!” The answer is both yes and no. Actually the question is akin to “Isn't Apple and Fruit the same? After all they both grow on trees!”. Without further ado, let us see the actual difference.

Mediated reality is a way to alter your perception of your surroundings by adding or removing information from it. Removing is the keyword here. While augmented reality is achieved by adding information to the perception of our surroundings, removing information from surrounding would qualify for mediation as well.

Virtual Reality

Much before augmentation was linked to reality, virtualization was. Virtual reality was a term which has been flashed a lot in recent past. Geeks who love to watch TV channels of the likes of Discovery and National Geographic would have been hearing the term for quite some time now. However, if you were having a vacation on Mars all this while, it would be great to get informed about virtual reality before we proceed further.

The term ‘virtual reality’ is easily one of the most self-contradicting terms ever coined – an oxymoron, if you will – though it is simple enough to understand. Virtual reality means a ‘reality’ which ‘imaginary’. But understand that this is not just imagination or processes that happen in the mind. It is sensory perception that is induced by tools from the real world. The term refers to simulation of reality in a way that it looks and feels real but is not. Science is pushing boundaries everyday to cover the feeling part well enough.